

TO THE EDITOR OF THE TIMES.

Sir,—It is a difficult thing to bring the public mind to think that a man who deliberately kills his five children ought not to be hanged as an example to deter others from doing the same thing. In the case of the convict Gouldstone there is reason to believe that what he wanted was to compass his own death, and he adopted an irrational method to accomplish what he desired. In any other case than murder an irrational act is accepted as ground at least for suspicion that the mind of the perpetrator is disordered; but in cases of murder no account is taken of the unreason of the act. The fact that a man of good character, under the influence of a cause, or causes, held to be utterly inadequate by persons of sound mind, suddenly commits an act inconsistent with all his previous history is in any other event than the perpetration of murder regarded as a very serious symptom arousing the most anxious fears on the part of his friends, especially if he has insane relations, but the law ignores all this, and asserts that a man is responsible for his actions if he knows the nature and quality of the act he commits, and that it is forbidden by law. This standard of responsibility is directly opposed to the established judgment of every person who has had any experience of the disordered mind. I sympathize with Dr. Savage as to his sense of duty as a recognized authority in such a matter, impelling him to make a public appeal for some further investigation of the circumstances. I agree with him that the act of William Gouldstone, taking into account the whole history, was an insane act, and none the less so because on every other subject his conduct and conversation was rational.

I am, Sir, your obedient servant,
W. WOOD, M.D., Physician to St. Luke's Hospital,
No. 99, Harley-street, Sept. 17.